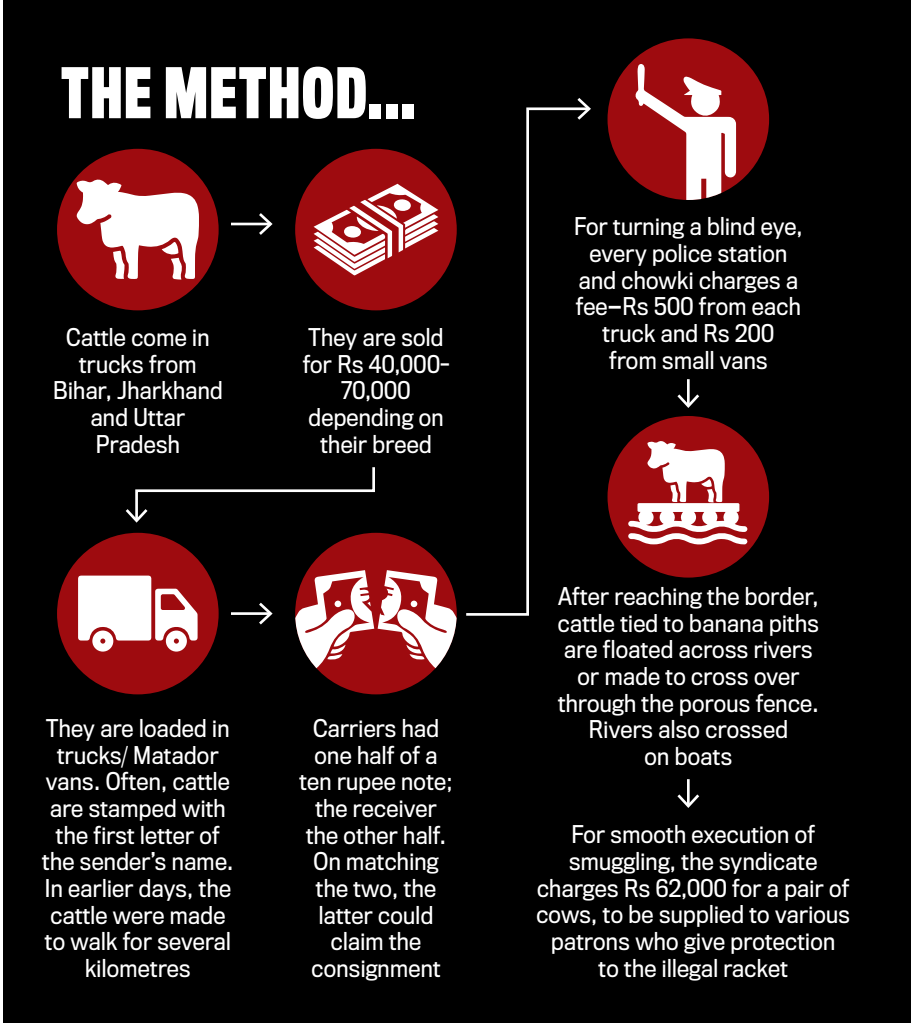
with the patronage and protection of the authorities at various levels. His diary is said to be a revelation—rich with names of kickback recipients, some of whom are said to be VVIPs. The entire cast of beneficiaries is now under the CBI and ED radar for unaccounted wealth and disproportionate assets.

Though cattle smuggling is not exactly new to Bengal, it was minuscule compared to the scale it has allegedly acquired during the TMC regime, with a fully fledged superstructure. An organised racket that gives high returns in liquid cash, huge numbers of people have been drawn into it over the past decade. With gainful employment hard to come by in the absence of industry, it is an easy choice for many. And a ready market for cows awaits just across the border in Bangladesh.

Of the 2,100 km-long West Bengal-Bangladesh international border, 913 km is under the watch of the South Bengal Frontier of the BSF. Of this, 538 km is unfenced and there are over a dozen points on this porous border swathe from Malda down to North 24 Parganas—like Lohapur in Birbhum and Umarpur in Murshidabad—through which cattle smuggling finds a smooth passage. A head of cattle, which costs Rs 40,000-50,000 in India, fetches four times the price in Bangladesh. BSF official records say 76,091 cattle, worth a staggering Rs 76 crore, were seized in anti-smuggling operations between 2018 and 2022. The number of cattle seized, though, went down from 38,657 in 2018 to 1,611 in 2021, according to Amrish Kumar Arya, DIG, South Bengal Frontier of BSF.

THE METHOD...



UNLIKE IN THE PAST, SMUGGLING HAS BECOME AN **ORGANISED AFFAIR, WITH VEHICLES CARRYING CATTLE** ACROSS THE BORDER, THE NUMBER OF TRUCKS ACCOUNTED FOR AND PAYMENT SETTLED IN MAFIA STYLE

↘ SMUGGLERS OLD AND NEW

Hours before dawn every Saturday, hundreds of trucks and other vehicles congregate on a nondescript area by the old NH 60, turning it into the bustling Sukhbazar market. Some are from other parts of Bengal; most come from Bihar, Jharkhand and Uttar Pradesh. The number of cattle on a given market day varies from 5,000 to 10,000. Once business gets over, cattle designated for Bangladesh are crammed into vehicles to be driven off to the hubs for the final send-off. Two short routes—one from Lohapur and another from Pachundi Gorur Haat in East Burdwan—lead to Morgram or Umarpur in Murshidabad, the terminal points for the final despatch to Bangladesh. The international border with Bangladesh is 20-25 km from Morgram and Umarpur. The final crossover point of choice is Bogura Ghat. According to the CBI, Enamul's key aide Abdul Latif procured the cattle while Mondal was paid a handsome share for creating a safe passage till the Bangladesh border.

Earlier, *rakhal* boys or *daakiyas* (young herdsmen) were hired to walk the cattle to the borders for Rs 100-500. Now, vehicles have largely replaced them. Everyone involved in the alleged racket, including security personnel, know the exact number of vehicles, the head of cattle in each and the amount due to them. They do not even need to handle unruly herds of cattle. Interestingly, nor do truck drivers who bring the cattle to the market from various states. Their place is